MEDIA RELEASE

FOR	DATE	SPOKESPERSON	MEDIA CONTACT
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VICTORIA · MELBOURNE

The Australian Democrats are back: historic return to Victorian State politics after 20 years

> **"Keep the Bastards Honest" — the Australian Democrats officially return to the Victorian ballot, clearing the way to contest the November 2026 Victorian State Election.**

The Australian Democrats have officially returned to Victorian state politics after successfully completing the Victorian Electoral Commission's (VEC) registration process, clearing the way for the party to contest the November 2026 Victorian State Election.

The milestone marks the first time in approximately 20 years that the Australian Democrats have been registered to contest a Victorian state election.

Importantly, the Australian Democrats have continued to contest federal elections throughout this period, with only one exception. The party has therefore remained a part of Australia's federal political landscape, but November's Victorian election will mark its first state-level contest in Victoria in two decades.

The Victorian registration represents a remarkable political resurrection for one of Australia's most recognisable political movements — and comes as the party experiences an extraordinary resurgence membership across Victoria.

Over the past six months, the Australian Democrats have more than tripled their membership base, with Victorians from across the political spectrum joining the party.

Victorian & Tasmanian State President Ryan Parris said the successful registration marked the beginning of a new chapter for the Australian Democrats.

> *"The Australian Democrats are officially back in Victorian politics."*
>
> *"We have achieved something that many people simply didn't believe was possible. We have rebuilt our membership, mobilised an incredible group of volunteers and successfully navigated the VEC registration process."*
>
> *"But this isn't about looking backwards. It's about looking forward."*
>
> **— Ryan Parris, Victorian & Tasmanian State President**

Victorians are looking for an alternative

The Australian Democrats' resurgence comes at a time when the party says voters are increasingly disenchanted with the major political parties and are searching for an alternative.

Mr Parris said the rapid growth in membership demonstrated that Victorians were prepared to look beyond traditional party politics.

> *"People are tired of political tribalism. They are tired of being told they have to choose between one major party and another."*
>
> *"What we're hearing from our members is simple: they want an alternative."*
>
> *"And importantly, they don't want an alternative that is untested. The Australian Democrats have a proven history of standing up for transparency, accountability, human rights, good government and parliamentary scrutiny."*
>
> **— Ryan Parris**

The Australian Democrats established a reputation as an independent political force during their decades in the Australian Senate, frequently using their balance of power to scrutinise governments and influence legislation.

The party says that independent approach is needed now more than ever, and will be focused on the upper house in the upcoming Victorian election, to hold power to account.

> *"We don't exist to blindly support Labor, Liberal, National, Greens or anyone else."*
>
> *"Our job is to represent the public interest, scrutinise government and, where necessary, keep those in power honest."*
>
> **— Ryan Parris**

A 50-year legacy — and a slogan that still rings true

The Australian Democrats' return to Victorian politics comes as the party prepares to celebrate a major milestone.

In April 2027, the Australian Democrats will mark 50 years since their formation in 1977.

For a political party returning to the Victorian ballot after two decades, the timing is significant.

And as the Australian Democrats approach their 50th anniversary, one of their most famous political slogans remains as relevant today as it was nearly half a century ago:

KEEP THE BASTARDS HONEST

> *"That slogan has become part of Australian political history."*
>
> *"It was cheeky, it was bold, and it captured exactly what the Australian Democrats were about."*
>
> *"Nearly 50 years later, the fundamental principle behind it hasn't changed."*
>
> *"Governments need scrutiny. Opposition parties need scrutiny. Political institutions need scrutiny. And most importantly, voters need representatives who are prepared to ask the difficult questions and hold power to account."*
>
> *"That's what the Australian Democrats were created to do — and that's what we are coming back to do."*
>
> **— Ryan Parris**

A new chapter begins

The successful VEC registration means Victorian voters will once again have the opportunity to vote for Australian Democrats candidates at a Victorian state election.

The party says it will now turn its attention towards selecting candidates, developing its election platform and building its campaign organisation ahead of November.

Mr Parris said the registration campaign had demonstrated the strength of the party's renewed volunteer base.

> *"This achievement belongs to our members and volunteers."*
>
> *"Hundreds of people have made phone calls, sent messages, contacted members, checked records and worked tirelessly behind the scenes to get us across the line."*
>
> *"We didn't buy our way back into Victorian politics. We rebuilt this movement from the ground up."*
>
> *"And what we've achieved in six months gives us enormous confidence about what we can achieve over the next six months."*
>
> **— Ryan Parris**

The Australian Democrats are back. Victoria now has another choice. And we're ready to Keep the Bastards Honest.

MEDIA ENQUIRIES

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